



All-rounder: Aryna Sabalenka boasts the athleticism, technique, and versatility to flourish on every surface.

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and 2024 breakout star Jasmine Paolini, losing just four games in each match. The feast-or-famine 'Penko' has also lost nine times in the first or second round this season.

On the pudgy side, she has a fitness coach but, oddly, no traditional coach. "No matter who coaches Jelena, she's always her own coach," said *Tennis Channel* analyst CoCo Vandeweghe.

Contrasting herself now with the 20-year-old who conquered Roland Garros, Ostapenko said, "At that time I was probably fearless, but I didn't have that much experience. I think honestly now I'm a better player — mentally as well. Getting a bit older and more mature is going to help

me." Ostapenko won't win another French Open, but getting to the semis won't surprise anyone.

No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka

Unlike Osaka, who won her four Grand Slam titles on hard courts but fared decidedly worse on clay and grass, Sabalenka — the reigning Queen of Hard Courts — boasts the athleticism, technique, and versatility to flourish on every surface. And, crucially, she believes that.

Marrying finesse to her serving, groundstroke power, and volleying skill, the 27-year-old Belarusian had won 23 of her last 27 matches (85%) on clay going into the Italian Open.

"Sabalenka is an absolute frontrunner," said former No. 9 Andrea Petkovic, now a *Tennis Channel* analyst. "Once she gets rolling, it's very hard to slow her down."

No wonder she ranks No. 1 in both serving and returning statistics

on the WTA Tour. And although she plays very few tiebreaks because she wins so many sets decisively, she holds a near-perfect 6-1 record in them.

Asked about her chances this season, Sabalenka said, "Physically I'm strong, and I'm not rushing the point, and I know I can stay in the point for however long I need. I think that's the key, because I think I have everything to be a good player on clay." Sabalenka proved that in spades at Madrid, where she won her third title there, defeating Gauff 6-3, 7-6 in the final.

The most emotional champion since Serena, she'll be ecstatic if she wins her first Grand Slam title on clay.

Best of the Rest: Jasmine Paolini, Zheng Qinwen, Clara Tauson

Dark Horses: Peyton Stearns, Victoria Mboko, Alexandra Eala, and Marta Kostyuk